

The Gen Z FOUNDERS' PLAYBOOK

RAISED ON AI, SMARTPHONES AND GLOBAL ACCESS, GEN Z START-UP FOUNDERS ARE REWRITING THE COUNTRY'S INNOVATION PLAYBOOK BY COMPETING GLOBALLY, AND LOOKING BEYOND QUICK EXITS

BY **PALAK AGARWAL**

NAMAN PUSHP, THE 21-year-old founder of aerospace start-up Airbound, belongs to the third generation of entrepreneurs—one trying to build technologies relevant to the world, not Indian versions of concepts existing elsewhere.

The earliest generation, 20 years ago, may have dreamt of building the local equivalents of global online marketplaces Amazon and Alibaba, and ride-sharing app Uber. That dream produced Flipkart, Snapdeal and Ola.

Ten years later, the second generation was designing products to suit India's unique realities—from social commerce sites like Meesho and quick delivery grocery app Zepto to digital payment platforms such as Paytm.

"Companies like Meesho and Zepto pioneered models that work exceptionally well for India," says Pushp, whose Bengaluru-based start-up is developing autonomous, zero-infrastructure drones to slash the cost of last-mile delivery.

"But what excites me is building something universal. We're not trying to make the Indian version of something that already exists. We're targeting the same problem statements that the best companies in the world are solving—and trying to solve them better," he says.

Raised on Artificial Intelligence (AI), smartphones and global digital access, India's under-30 Gen Z founders like Pushp are less interested in adapting foreign ideas to India than in building technologies the world can use.

From space surveillance platform Digantara and Airbound to quick commerce leader Zepto and AI-native ventures emerging from research labs, they are entering sectors demanding greater technical depth, longer development cycles and vaster global ambitions.

They are not just building companies in a different funding environment from what prevailed in the days of their predecessors; they are redefining success in India's startup ecosystem in the age of AI.

The demographic shift is significant. Boston Consulting Group says India's Gen Z, numbering 377 million, is the